

“Strike for your lives and liberties ... Rather die freemen than live to be slaves.”

HENRY HIGHLAND GARNET, IN A SPEECH DELIVERED IN BUFFALO,
AUGUST 21, 1843

The postal campaign of 1835

The abolitionists were a tiny minority, but they used newspapers and the postal system to spread their message—even to the South. In 1835, members of the AAS gathered the names and addresses of politicians, clergymen, businessmen, and prominent citizens to create a national mailing list. They then mailed abolitionist papers, pamphlets, tracts, children’s books, and sheet music across the nation, including the South.

Southerners were outraged. Many Southern states had already banned the circulation of abolitionist literature, and President Andrew Jackson authorized postmasters to censor the mails as they saw fit. Mail bags were opened and literature deemed inflammatory was seized and frequently burned. Even Northerners opposed to these tactics by abolitionists were troubled by this restriction on the free speech of fellow white citizens.

Southern politicians demanded that public “agitation” about slavery cease as a matter of safety and sectional peace. Southern Democrats and Whigs agreed that the right of citizens to petition Congress on the subject of slavery must also stop. A “gag rule” was devised that blocked presentation of citizen petitions in Congress between 1836 and 1844.

Violence against abolitionists

In a nation where slavery was legal and its products formed the core of the export economy, abolitionists often met a hostile response. Many people resented their attacks on the political system, while an